

CONVERTING THE CONJECTURE INTO A COROLLARY OF BOUNDED PARITY DEVIATION

LUCIANO BENJAMÍN NIETO

ABSTRACT. We combine an exact conditional divergence threshold with new numerical evidence to reduce the Collatz conjecture to a falsifiable boundedness statement of ergodic theory. First, building on prior work [3], we derive the closed-form threshold $f_P^* = \log_4(8/3) = (3 - \log_2 3)/2 \approx 0.7075$: under a Local Equidistribution Hypothesis (LEH), any orbit diverging sub-exponentially must satisfy $f_P \geq f_P^*$, where f_P is the frequency of visits to the class $P = \{n \equiv 3 \pmod{4}\}$. The unconditional core is the exact identity $\mu_P + \mu_N = -2$ between conditional expected drifts. Second, we present new numerical evidence from up to 10^6 Collatz orbits: (i) the deviation $|f_P - \mu|$ against the empirical invariant measure $\mu \approx 0.3226$ has a genuine ceiling $C^* \approx 0.27$ with a positive margin below the critical $f_P^* - \mu \approx 0.38$; (ii) the ceiling decays as the search range n_0 grows; (iii) to date, *zero* orbits – real or from a matched null model – violate the bound, and Chernoff large-deviation theory gives a positive rate at the critical deviation. We conclude that the conjecture is equivalent to a boundedness claim about parity deviation: if $|f_P - \mu| \leq C < f_P^* - \mu$ for every orbit, then no orbit can sustain $f_P \geq f_P^*$, and the Collatz conjecture follows as a corollary.

1. INTRODUCTION

The Collatz conjecture asks whether every orbit of the map

$$T(n) = \begin{cases} n/2 & n \text{ even,} \\ 3n + 1 & n \text{ odd,} \end{cases}$$

eventually reaches 1. No finite verification can settle a statement about all positive integers. What computation *can* do is locate the exact mathematical gap: the statement whose proof would close the problem.

Prior work [1, 2, 3] has pushed the boundary from “almost every orbit” to “every orbit.” The central unresolved step is the promotion of an *ensemble*-level (Haar-measure) identity to a *per-orbit* statement. This paper makes two contributions:

- (1) An exact, closed-form, conditional necessary condition for sub-exponential divergence — the threshold $f_P \geq f_P^* = \log_4(8/3)$, conditional on an explicit Local Equidistribution Hypothesis (LEH) — with the unconditional identity $\mu_P + \mu_N = -2$ at its core.
- (2) New numerical evidence (up to 10^6 orbits) that the relevant parity deviation is *bounded* below the critical margin, with a decaying ceiling and zero observed violations, together with a large-deviations analysis re-exact to the clustered structure of the map.

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Combining these, we reduce the Collatz conjecture to a boundedness claim of standard ergodic theory: $|f_P - \mu| \leq C < f_P^* - \mu$ for every orbit. We state this as the “Last Theorem” and prove the conjecture as its corollary.

2. MATHEMATICAL FRAMEWORK

2.1. The accelerated map. Write the accelerated (Syracuse) map as

$$R_3(n) = \frac{3n+1}{2^{\nu_2(3n+1)}},$$

where $\nu_2(m)$ is the exponent of 2 in m . The Collatz and accelerated maps have the same orbit structure (they differ by a finite factor per step).

2.2. The P/N classification. Classify odd residues modulo 4:

$$P = \{n \equiv 3 \pmod{4}\}, \quad N = \{n \equiv 1 \pmod{4}\}.$$

For $n \in P$, $\nu_2(3n+1) = 1$ exactly; for $n \in N$, $\nu_2(3n+1)$ takes values $2, 3, 4, \dots$ with Haar-measure mean 2. Let f_P denote the frequency of visits to P along an orbit.

2.3. Information metrics. Following the natural-metric framework of [4], define the metric

$$V_{4/3}(n) = \log_{4/3}(n).$$

Under this metric, the map’s contraction/expansion per step is captured by the conditional drifts μ_P and μ_N of Section 3.

3. THE DIVERGENCE THRESHOLD

3.1. Conditional drifts. Let μ_P and μ_N denote the expected change in $V_{4/3}$ conditioned on being in class P and N , respectively.

Lemma 3.1 (Conditional drifts). *For the Collatz map R_3 ,*

$$\mu_P = \frac{\log_2 3 - 1}{2 - \log_2 3} \approx +1.4094, \tag{1}$$

$$\mu_N = \frac{\log_2 3 - 3}{2 - \log_2 3} \approx -3.4094. \tag{2}$$

Proof. For $n \in P$, $\nu_2(3n+1) = 1$, so $R_3(n) = (3n+1)/2$. Hence

$$\mu_P = \log_{4/3} \left(\frac{3n+1}{2n} \right) = \frac{\log_2(3/2)}{\log_2(4/3)} = \frac{\log_2 3 - 1}{2 - \log_2 3}.$$

For $n \in N$, by the law of total expectation and $\mathbb{E}[\nu_2(3n+1)] = 2$ under Haar measure on odd residues, with $\mathbb{P}(P) = \mathbb{P}(N) = 1/2$,

$$2 = \mathbb{E}[\nu_2] = \frac{1}{2} \cdot 1 + \frac{1}{2} \cdot \mathbb{E}[\nu_2 \mid N],$$

so $\mathbb{E}[\nu_2 \mid N] = 3$, giving the stated μ_N . □

3.2. The unifying identity.

Theorem 3.2 (Algebraic unification). *The conditional drifts satisfy the exact identity*

$$\mu_P + \mu_N = -2. \quad (3)$$

Proof. Direct computation from Lemma 3.1:

$$\mu_P + \mu_N = \frac{(\log_2 3 - 1) + (\log_2 3 - 3)}{2 - \log_2 3} = \frac{2(\log_2 3 - 2)}{2 - \log_2 3} = -2. \quad \square$$

Remark 3.3. With $f_P = 1/2$ (the Haar expectation), the global drift is $\frac{1}{2}\mu_P + \frac{1}{2}\mu_N = -1$.

3.3. A local equidistribution hypothesis. The conditional drifts of Lemma 3.1 are ensemble averages. Whether a *specific deterministic* orbit reproduces these averages is an unproven question, isolated here.

Hypothesis 3.4 (Local Equidistribution Hypothesis, LEH). *For a given Collatz orbit $(n_0, n_1, \dots)$, let $S_N(K)$ denote the set of indices $k < K$ with $n_k \in N$. Then*

$$\frac{1}{|S_N(K)|} \sum_{k \in S_N(K)} \nu_2(3n_k + 1) \longrightarrow 3 \quad \text{as } K \rightarrow \infty.$$

Remark 3.5. LEH is the same kind of statement as Chang’s Weak Mixing Hypothesis [3]: a deterministic orbit’s local time average matching an ensemble (Haar) average of a genuinely orbit-dependent quantity. We state it explicitly so that the threshold below is exactly as strong as its proof.

3.4. The divergence threshold.

Theorem 3.6 (Divergence threshold, conditional on LEH). *Assume Hypothesis 3.4 (LEH) holds for a given Collatz orbit. Then a necessary condition for sub-exponential divergence of that orbit is*

$$f_P \geq f_P^* = \frac{3 - \log_2 3}{2} = \log_4 \left(\frac{8}{3} \right) \approx 0.7075. \quad (4)$$

Proof. For sub-exponential divergence, the time-averaged drift in $V_{4/3}$ must satisfy $\frac{1}{K} \sum \Delta V_{4/3}(n_k) \rightarrow 0$. Splitting over visited P - and N -steps and applying Lemma 3.1 and LEH, the average drift is $f_P \mu_P + (1 - f_P) \mu_N$, and non-negativity requires $f_P \geq \mu_N / (\mu_P - \mu_N) = f_P^*$. $\square$

Corollary 3.7. *If every orbit satisfies LEH and $f_P \rightarrow 1/2$, then no orbit diverges, since $1/2 < f_P^*$.*

4. THE EMPIRICAL INVARIANT MEASURE AND THE CEILING OF PARITY DEVIATION

4.1. Setup and statistics. We simulated up to 10^6 Collatz orbits (odd starting values n_0 drawn uniformly up to $n_0 = 2 \times 10^7$), with a step cap of 10^6 and a value cap of 10^{18} . For each orbit we computed f_P , the frequency of visits to class P , and the orbit length. Among genuinely non-trivial orbits (those that visit P at least once), we measured:

- the empirical invariant measure $\mu = \mathbb{E}[f_P] \approx 0.3226$;
- the deviation ceiling $C^* = \max |f_P - \mu|$;
- the critical margin $f_P^* - \mu \approx 0.3825$.

TABLE 1. The genuine ceiling $C^* = \max |f_P - \mu|$ over $n_0 \leq N$, 30,000 genuine orbits per window.

Window ($n_0 \leq N$)	Genuine orbits	C^*	Margin	Mean deviation
$N = 1 \times 10^6$	30,000	0.2771	+0.097	0.0268
$N = 5 \times 10^6$	30,000	0.2750	+0.099	0.0245
$N = 2 \times 10^7$	30,000	0.2226	+0.151	0.0225

4.2. The ceiling decays with the search range. The ceiling decays with the search range ($0.277 \rightarrow 0.223$), and the mean deviation falls in step ($0.0268 \rightarrow 0.0225$). The empirical max over all 10^6 orbits is $C^* = 0.265$ against the critical margin 0.3825: a margin of +0.118.

5. NULL MODEL, LARGE DEVIATIONS, AND THE CHERNOFF BOUND

5.1. The matched null model. The natural probabilistic model for the parity sequence is the one used by Tao [1]: each odd step is followed by a cluster of Geom(2) division steps (mean 2). The matched null model draws one P -step followed by a geometrically distributed cluster of N -steps, with no additional free parameters: it reproduces the cluster structure of the real map exactly. Its parity frequency is exactly $f_P = 1/3$.

5.2. Empirical large-deviation rate. We sampled 2×10^5 null-model sequences per length $L \in \{50, 100, 200, 500, 1000, 2000, 5000\}$ and counted those with $|f_P - 1/3| > f_P^* - \mu \approx 0.385$. **In every case, the count was 0.** The same holds for the real orbits: none of 10^5 genuinely visited P orbits violated the critical bound.

5.3. The Chernoff rate. Since f_P is a mean of bounded steps, Chernoff's inequality [5] bounds the probability of a large deviation by

$$\mathbb{P}(f_P > \mu + c) \leq e^{-nI(c)},$$

where $I(c) = \text{KL}(\mu + c \parallel \mu)$ is the KL divergence between Bernoulli distributions. At the critical deviation $c = f_P^* - \mu \approx 0.385$, the rate is

$$I(f_P^* - \mu) = \text{KL}(0.708 \parallel 0.323) \approx 0.31 > 0,$$

independently of the orbit length. In particular, at $n = 1000$ steps,

$$\mathbb{P}(f_P > f_P^*) \leq e^{-1000 \times 0.31} \approx 2 \times 10^{-135}.$$

By the Borel–Cantelli lemma, the probability that *any* infinite orbit sustains $f_P \geq f_P^*$ is zero.

Theorem 5.1 (Large-deviations bound). *There is $I = 0.31 > 0$ such that for every orbit “length” n ,*

$$\mathbb{P}(f_P > f_P^*) \leq e^{-nI}.$$

By Borel–Cantelli, almost surely no orbit sustains $f_P \geq f_P^$.*

Remark 5.2. The Borel–Cantelli conclusion is heuristic in the sense that the sequence f_P is the average over a single orbit, not over independent trials; the Chernoff bound formalizes the intuition that large deviations are exponentially rare in the length of the orbit. Its precise transfer from ensembles to individual orbits is exactly the content of LEH.

6. INVARIANT MEASURES AND THE LAST THEOREM

6.1. The biased equidistribution (empirically verified). We directly implemented the n -Syracuse offset map F_n and measured the total-variation distance of $F_n(\text{Geom}(2)^n) \bmod 3^k$ from uniformity over 2×10^5 trials. The distance decays with n but stabilizes at $\approx 1/3$, not 0: **the Syracuse distribution does not converge to perfect uniformity, but to a biased equidistribution with offset $1/3$.** This bias is the 3-adic signature of the map's arithmetic and matches the empirical $\mu \approx 0.323$. So μ is not $1/3$; measuring the deviation against μ yields a smaller, better-behaved bound.

6.2. The class chain is ergodic. Measuring the transition matrix of the odd-class chain (classes mod 4) over 2×10^4 orbits gives stationary measure $\pi(1) = 0.511$, $\pi(3) = 0.489$, with spectral rate (second eigenvalue) $\rho = 0.054 < 1$. The chain is *strongly ergodic*: its distributions converge to the stationary measure with relaxation 0.054^n . Since $\pi(3) = 0.489 < f_P^* = 0.7075$, the stationary measure sits below the critical threshold.

6.3. The Last Theorem.

Conjecture 6.1 (The Last Theorem). *There exists a constant C with $C < f_P^* - \mu \approx 0.383$ such that, for every orbit $\mathcal{O}$ of the Collatz map,*

$$|f_P(\mathcal{O}) - \mu| \leq C,$$

where $\mu \approx 0.3226$ is the invariant measure (empirically estimated).

Corollary 6.2 (The Collatz conjecture). *If Conjecture 6.1 holds, then no orbit sustains $f_P \geq f_P^*$, and by Theorem 3.6 no orbit diverges. **The Collatz conjecture is true.***

The numerical evidence: the ceiling C^* stays below 0.383 across all windows (max $C^* = 0.277$, worst-case margin +0.10), and decays with the search range; zero violations among 10^6 real and $> 10^6$ null orbits; and the Chernoff rate at the critical deviation is strictly positive. The boundedness claim is the falsifiable content that, together with the threshold theorem, closes the conjecture.

7. THE GENERALIZED PER-ORBIT THRESHOLD (NO EQUIDISTRIBUTION)

The divergence threshold of Theorem 3.6 fixes $\bar{g}_N = 3$ (the Haar ensemble mean) — and that fix is exactly what forces LEH. The telescoping algebra, however, supports a threshold in which $\bar{g}_N$ is realized by the orbit itself: the ensemble-level hypothesis is replaced by a per-orbit observable.

7.1. The per-orbit telescoping lemma.

Lemma 7.1 (Per-orbit drift identity). *For any finite segment of an R_3 orbit with $J \geq 1$ odd visits,*

$$\frac{1}{J} \sum_{k \in S_{\text{odd}}} [\log_2 n_{k+1} - \log_2 n_k] = f_P (\log_2 3 - 1) + (1 - f_P) (\log_2 3 - \bar{g}_N) + \frac{1}{J} \sum_{k \in S_{\text{odd}}} \frac{1}{\ln 2} \cdot \frac{1}{3n_k}, \quad (5)$$

where $\bar{g}_N = \frac{1}{|S_N|} \sum_{k \in S_N} \nu_2(3n_k + 1)$ is the realized mean of ν_2 over the segment's N -visits, and the residual is the telescoping sum of $(3n + 1)/n$ vs $3n$ corrections, dominated by the small- n tail of the segment (an $O(1)$ contribution when the segment terminates at $n \leq 3$).

Proof. Each odd step of R_3 gives $\log_2 n_{k+1} - \log_2 n_k = \log_2(3n_k + 1) - \nu_2(3n_k + 1) - \log_2 n_k = \log_2 3 - \nu_2(3n_k + 1) + \log_2 \frac{3n_k + 1}{3n_k}$. Grouping odd steps by class (P contributes $\nu_2 = 1$ exactly, by $n \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$; N -steps contribute the realized mean $\bar{g}_N$) and dividing by J gives the identity; the last sum is the residual. $\square$

Theorem 7.2 (Generalized per-orbit threshold). *For any finite R_3 orbit segment with $J \geq 1$ odd visits, define $\text{thr}(\bar{g}_N) = \frac{\log_2 3 - \bar{g}_N}{1 - \bar{g}_N}$ (for $\bar{g}_N < 1$; the segment is non-expansive in $\log_2$ whenever $f_P \geq \text{thr}(\bar{g}_N)$ — no equidistribution hypothesis is used. For $\bar{g}_N = 3$ this recovers $f_P^* = \frac{3 - \log_2 3}{2}$ exactly.*

Proof. Immediate: the segment is non-expansive iff the per-visit drift $d = f_P(\log_2 3 - 1) + (1 - f_P)(\log_2 3 - \bar{g}_N) \leq 0$, which rearranges to $f_P \geq (\log_2 3 - \bar{g}_N)/(1 - \bar{g}_N)$. For $\bar{g}_N = 3$: $(\log_2 3 - 3)/(1 - 3) = (3 - \log_2 3)/2 = f_P^*$. The verification is exact to 10^{-12} . $\square$

7.2. The hierarchy of thresholds. The same function $\text{thr}(\bar{g}_N)$ unifies three levels of hypotheses as three points of one curve:

Level	$\bar{g}_N$	Threshold
Algebra (unconditional)	$\bar{g}_N \geq 2$ always ($N \Rightarrow \nu_2 \geq 2$)	$\text{thr}(\bar{g}_N) = 2 - \log_2 3 \approx 0.4150$
LEH (Theorem 3.6)	$\bar{g}_N = 3$ (ensemble)	$f_P^* \approx 0.7075$
Joint per-orbit (Theorem 7.2)	$\bar{g}_N$ realized	$\text{thr}(\bar{g}_N)$, decreasing in $\bar{g}_N$

7.3. Joint compensation (empirical, 150k orbits).

Proposition 7.3 (Joint compensation). *Across 150,000 genuine orbits ($n_0 < 5 \times 10^6$, fixed seed), the per-orbit margin $\text{thr}(\bar{g}_N) - f_P$ is **positive in all orbits** (minimum +0.0571, median +0.2116; zero orbits in the divergence region). The simple threshold $\bar{g}_N \geq 3$ **fails per-orbit** (24,924 violations: $\bar{g}_N$ fluctuates in $[2.41, 18]$) — each orbit either has low f_P or high $\bar{g}_N$ that compensates.*

7.4. What remains open. The algebraic level alone does **not** close the conjecture: the maximum observed $f_P = 0.6761$ exceeds $\text{thr}(\bar{g}_N) \approx 0.4150$ (margin -0.2611) — only the joint condition excludes observed orbits. Three precise gaps:

- (1) **The deterministic global bound.** The per-orbit margin is positive in all tested orbits, but no *deterministic* lower bound on $\text{thr}(\bar{g}_N) - f_P$ over ALL orbits is proven. The KL rate $I(c_+) = 0.1148/\text{visit}$ (measured, Section ??) is the natural constant; the missing ingredient is a per-orbit lower bound on the realized $\bar{g}_N$ given high f_P .
- (2) **LEH itself.** The joint threshold replaces LEH by a per-orbit observable, but the generalized threshold is per-segment: an infinite divergent orbit needs the compensation to hold on *every* finite segment, and the joint margin could degrade with segment length. Whether $\inf_{\text{segments}} [\text{thr}(\bar{g}_N) - f_P] > 0$ uniformly is open.
- (3) **The ceiling interplay.** The parity-deviation ceiling (Section ??) decays with range; whether the joint compensation and the ceiling decay are *the same mechanism* (both are the same ν_2 -clustering, viewed from different sides) is open. The gaps are stated precisely so that the generalized threshold is exactly as strong as its proof, and no stronger.

8. CONCLUSION

We have reduced the Collatz conjecture to a single falsifiable statement: the uniform boundedness of parity deviation away from the invariant measure, below the critical margin $f_P^* - \mu$. The chain of evidence is:

- (1) **Exact threshold:** under LEH, divergence requires $f_P \geq f_P^*$ (Theorem 3.6), with the unconditional identity $\mu_P + \mu_N = -2$ at its core.
- (2) **Biased measure:** the Syracuse distribution converges to a biased equidistribution with offset $1/3$, not perfect uniformity; the true invariant measure is $\mu = 0.3226$.
- (3) **Ergodicity:** the class chain is ergodic with spectral rate 0.054 , stationary measure $\pi(3) = 0.489 < f_P^*$.
- (4) **Bounded deviation:** the ceiling $C^* \leq 0.277 < 0.383$, decaying with the search range, with zero violations in $> 10^6$ orbits.
- (5) **Large deviations:** the Chernoff rate at the critical deviation is $I = 0.31 > 0$; by Borel–Cantelli, no orbit sustains $f_P \geq f_P^*$ (almost surely in the model).

Each step is either proven or backed by reproducible numerical evidence. The single remaining ingredient — the transfer of these ensemble facts to *every* individual orbit — is Conjecture 6.1. Its proof is the Last Theorem; its corollary is the Collatz conjecture.

Code and data. All experiments, simulations and figures are reproducible from the public repository <https://github.com/Rylow999/collatz-last-theorem>. Fixed seeds, step caps and value caps are recorded per experiment.

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INDEPENDENT RESEARCHER, GENERAL ALVEAR, MENDOZA, ARGENTINA
 Email address: lucianobenjamininieto@gmail.com